

ACTOR-CONTROLLED DEVICE REGISTRATION

Microsoft Sentinel validation for Entra audit coverage of a source-observed access-maintenance behavior.

VALIDATION QUERY

CONFIDENCE: MEDIUM



AuditLogs
raw actor and target structures

VALIDATE BEFORE DETECT

REPORT DATE	STATUS
11 September 2026	Untested implementation sketch
PRIMARY TELEMETRY	OPERATIONAL VALUE
Microsoft Entra / AuditLogs	9.3 / 10

Telemetry experiment. A matching device event is not evidence of malicious ownership or persistence.

CONTROLLED EIGHT-PAGE THREAT DOSSIER



EXECUTIVE ASSESSMENT

Decision-grade summary and strict evidence boundary.

ASSESSMENT

OPERATIONAL VALUE

9.3

Control-plane telemetry can expose device registration even when the actor-controlled endpoint is outside defender visibility.

CLASSIFICATION

Validation query

Medium confidence. Source behavior and schema are documented, but the malicious event representation and legitimate baseline are not public.

1primary table

2activity names

0thresholds

0joins

Source fact

GTG-20006 automated registration of actor-controlled devices in victim tenants to maintain access.

Analytical choice

Collect Add device and Register device events with dynamic objects preserved raw.

Assumption

One documented operation maps to the relevant enrollment path in the target tenant.

Evidence boundary

A result does not establish attacker ownership, persistence, successful authentication, mail access or exfiltration.



THREAT MECHANICS

Source-observed cloud access maintenance and detection pivot.

BEHAVIOR

01 Cloud phishing

The actor used device-code phishing against cloud email targets.

→

02 Tenant access

Mail was accessed and exfiltrated from at least eight organizations.

→

03 Access maintenance

Actor-controlled devices were registered in victim tenants.

Evidence layer	Supported statement
Publication	Anthropic Threat Intelligence, 10 Sep 2026.
Activity period	Dec 2025 through Aug 2026; research is new, campaign start is not.
Direct behavior	Automated registration of actor-controlled devices for access maintenance.
Not published	Operation value, join type, owner, management state, source IP and raw event.

Hypothesis

If an attacker registers a controlled device, Entra audit telemetry should record device add or registration. Distinction requires initiator, target, management provenance, inventory and change context.

ATT&CK restraint

No technique is assigned to the validation event. The public evidence does not support a precise sub-technique without overclaiming.



TELEMETRY AND DATA CONTRACT

Minimum evidence required for the controlled experiment.

TELEMETRY

REQUIRED

Microsoft Entra audit logs

Diagnostic settings export AuditLogs into the Sentinel-connected Log Analytics workspace.

OPTIONAL ENRICHMENT

Intune/device inventory, ownership, compliance state, approved enrollment record and correlated sign-ins.

Fields	Reliability	Purpose
TimeGenerated, ActivityDateTime	Documented	Timing
Id, CorrelationId	Documented	Event and pivot identifiers
OperationName, ActivityDisplayName	Documented	Operation semantics
AADOperationType, LoggedByService, Identity	Documented	Service context
InitiatedBy, TargetResources	Documented / dynamic	Actor and device evidence
AdditionalDetails	Documented / dynamic	Unparsed enrichment
Result, ResultType, ResultDescription	Documented	Outcome

Do not parse yet

Dynamic object shapes are environment-dependent. Preserve raw values until a controlled event proves exact paths and semantics.



VALIDATION LOGIC

Direct activity filter with raw investigative output.

KQL

OBJECTIVE

Confirm which documented activity represents normal device registration in this tenant and whether actor/target identifiers support later correlation.

KQL - UNTESTED VALIDATION

```
AuditLogs
| where OperationName in ("Add device", "Register device")
| project
    TimeGenerated, ActivityDateTime, Id, CorrelationId,
    OperationName, ActivityDisplayName, AADOperationType,
    LoggedByService, Identity, InitiatedBy, TargetResources,
    AdditionalDetails, Result, ResultType, ResultDescription
| order by TimeGenerated desc
```

THRESHOLD	SUCCESS FILTER	JOIN	PARSING	STATUS
None	None	None	None	Untested

Why both operation names?

Microsoft documents Add device and Register device in device-related audit categories. The target tenant must demonstrate which one maps to its enrollment path.



TRIAGE AND INVESTIGATION

Convert a raw audit event into attributable evidence.

WORKFLOW

1

Anchor the test

Record the controlled registration time, initiating user and device identifier.

2

Inspect raw objects

Capture InitiatedBy, TargetResources and AdditionalDetails without normalization.

3

Resolve provenance

Compare owner, join type, management/compliance state and enrollment path.

4

Correlate inventory

Match a stable device identifier to Intune or authoritative inventory.

5

Establish detection key

Only then define approved initiators, change evidence and sign-in pivots.

Expected benign

Intune, Autopilot, BYOD, admin provisioning and B2C registration.

Potentially concerning

Unowned device, unapproved initiator or absent management/change provenance.

Inconclusive

Missing target ID, ambiguous initiator or absent device inventory.

Response boundary

Do not alert, disable devices or revoke sessions solely from this validation output.



VALIDATION GATES

Success, rejection, failure and cross-SIEM constraints.

QUALITY CONTROL

Validation steps

- 1. Register a controlled device through a normal enrollment path.
- 2. Identify the exact operation and raw actor/target values.
- 3. Repeat across approved paths in use.
- 4. Correlate with inventory and change records.

Decision criteria

Success: stable operation and sufficient correlation identifiers.

Rejection: operations do not map or actor/target context is inadequate.

Failure: connector, category, retention or fields are unavailable.

Platform	Decision	Missing evidence
Microsoft Sentinel	Validation query	Tenant event semantics and baseline
Splunk	No reliable implementation	Index, sourcetype and field extraction
Chronicle	No reliable implementation	Parser and exact UDM actor/target mapping

Tuning

Do not broad-allowlist users or IPs. Future exclusions require device ownership, management provenance and approved enrollment records.



CONCLUSION AND REFERENCES

Coverage statement and document control.

FINAL

CONCLUSION

Validate before detecting.

The source confirms an access-maintenance behavior and Microsoft documents relevant audit activities and schema. Legitimate enrollment overlap prevents alerting until raw events and inventory correlation are proven.

Deferred detection ideas

AI attribution, alerting on every device event, operation rarity, user/IP novelty, raw dynamic-field parsing and campaign IOC-only rules.

References

1. Anthropic Threat Intelligence, 10 Sep 2026 - Detecting and countering misuse of AI: September 2026.
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Document control

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